

Checklist:

Thriving in Different Environments

1. Identify your team type

Product team

- I understand the customer/user problem my team is solving.
- I know how my work affects product, business, or user outcomes.
- I regularly talk with product managers, designers, data scientists, support staff, and users.
- I suggest product improvements, not just implement specs.
- I think through edge cases and tradeoffs before shipping.
- I validate whether a feature worked after launch.
- I build product intuition over time by learning from outcomes.

Platform team

- I understand who uses my platform and what they need.
- I know whether my customers are internal engineers, product teams, business teams, or end users.
- I make it easy for users to contact me and give feedback.
- I communicate proactively with teams building on the platform.
- I work side by side with platform customers when useful.
- I spend time with product teams to understand downstream impact.
- I balance deep focus with urgency when priorities change.

2. Recognize company mode: wartime or peacetime

Wartime signs

- The company faces existential or intense competitive pressure.

- Shipping quickly matters more than perfect quality.
- Deadlines are treated as mandatory.
- Meetings are reduced in favor of execution.
- Conflict is tolerated if it helps get important work done.
- Processes may be bypassed to move faster.
- Work-life balance is weak or deprioritized.

Peacetime signs

- The business has little immediate pressure.
- Quality, alignment, and validation matter more than speed.
- Deadlines are useful but not always critical.
- Meetings are common to maintain alignment.
- Conflict is discouraged.
- Process is expected to be followed.
- Work-life balance is a visible priority.

3. Adjust your behavior to the mode

To thrive in wartime

- Prioritize getting important work done quickly.
- Accept “good enough” when speed matters more than perfection.
- Don’t take blunt feedback or conflict personally.
- Build only the alliances needed to unblock execution.
- Stay aligned with your manager and skip-level leadership.
- Focus on business-critical priorities.
- Treat job stability as uncertain and keep options open.
- Manage stress and burnout actively.

To thrive in peacetime

- Prioritize high-quality execution.
- Avoid unnecessary conflict.
- Build relationships and alliances across teams.
- Manage upward, sideways, and downward.
- Work on longer-term initiatives that benefit the business.
- Use stability to improve systems and processes.
- Keep momentum without stagnating.
- Avoid becoming too comfortable or bored.

4. Understand your company type

Big Tech / large tech company

- I know whether my team is closer to product or platform work.
- I track my individual impact clearly.
- I keep evidence of achievements for reviews and promotion.
- I build relationships across the organization.
- I help others, knowing relationships may matter later.
- I understand how performance reviews and promotions work.

Mid- or late-stage scaleup

- I understand whether tenure is valuable in my organization.
- I use company knowledge to create impact.
- I help improve onboarding or knowledge sharing.
- I know whether my team is viewed as a cost center or profit center.
- I understand the company's growth phase and risk level.
- I stay alert during slowing growth or restructuring.

Early-stage startup

- I understand how my work helps the company reach product-market fit.
- I talk with founders, teammates, and customers to find high-impact work.
- I know the company may be risky or unstable.
- I use autonomy to move fast and take initiative.
- I make sure founders and leaders are aware of impactful work.
- I focus on creating value, not just completing assigned tasks.
- I prioritize getting the most important things done quickly.

5. Universal checklist for any company

- I know what my company values most: speed, quality, impact, reliability, or growth.
- I adapt my working style to the current environment.
- I do standout work by my company's standards.
- I help people around me succeed.
- I maintain strong relationships with peers and former colleagues.

- I resolve conflicts professionally.
- I avoid burning bridges.
- I regularly reassess whether the company has shifted modes.
- I stay ready to adapt when the environment changes.